So some sobriety and a greater awareness of the fragilities and uncertainties of these historical processes are called for. In the first place we need to escape misleading aggregations. China's growth has been nothing short of a miracle, but without it the whole picture changes. South Africa can't be said to be 'emerging' in any sense. The other members have had varying rates of more moderate accumulation – but all are facing difficulties with the US's attempts to manage the ongoing global crisis and the tapering of easy money (the US$ 'Quantitative Easing' printing press) in the wake of a major commodity price boom.

In a more globalised world, macro-statistics on GDP and trade mask a great deal. The Chinese boom is still deeply dependent on value chains that run through Western markets and are controlled by Western multinationals, which are still technological power-houses retaining ultimate controls through intellectual property and branding power. US military 'hard power' may be receding after its disasters in the Middle East and Afghanistan, plus recent spending cuts, but it still dwarfs the combined might of the BRICS. US military bases still cover the globe, and the rise of AFRICOM is a genuine threat to African self-determination. The dollar's position as world money also appears impregnable in the short run – having become the global safe-haven commodity during a crisis generated in the US itself. China now faces the daunting challenge of redirecting its economy from export production for debt-fuelled US markets to internal demand-driven growth, against the grain of entrenched political and economic interests.

BRICS nations also provide no solution to the most serious looming crisis – global warming – having collaborated with Western powers in Copenhagen and Durban UN summits to scupper any legally binding international convention on climate change. These caveats in mind, it is important to affirm that the shift in the economic structure of the world and the distribution of power is real and significant. It appears to be interfering with the ability of the US to manage global capitalism collaboratively with its traditional allies, the EU and Japan.

There may be something inherently progressive to this, and indeed to a greater geographic, national and racial diffusion of wealth and power. But the opportunities provided by a more multipolar world order will not be delivered from above. Only a 'new world order' that changes rather than spreads capitalist logics of power and profits can truly overturn global geographies of inequality.